

Calm & Oak

THE FREE CHEAT-SHEET

The Japandi Colour *Palette*

*Five palettes, every hex code,
and which room each one carries.*



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Three rules, *five colours.*

Japandi looks neutral, but the rooms that read calm aren't accidentally beige. They're built on three rules. Hold these three and almost any palette below works.

i

A warm base

Start with a warm neutral — oat, cream, or stone — never a cool blue-white. The base is the largest surface in the room (walls, big bedding) and it sets the whole room's temperature. Get this wrong and no accent can rescue it.

ii

Two woods, no more

One light wood (oak, ash) and at most one dark (walnut). Two woods read as a relationship; a third is where rooms start to feel busy. The wood is the foundation and the hardest thing to change — pick the palette that sits calmly on the wood you already own.

iii

One quiet accent

A single restrained note — terracotta, sage, or charcoal — used once or twice, never throughout. One accent keeps a room calm; two make it loud. Painting a whole wall the accent colour is the fastest way to overwhelm the palette.

01 Oat & oak

THE WARM DEFAULT

BASE	NEUTRAL	WOOD	ANCHOR	ACCENT
Cream #F4EEE2	Oat #E8DCC4	Light oak #C9A77C	Soft taupe #8A7A5C	Terracotta #C97B5C

Soft oat linen against light oak, with cream walls and a soft-taupe depth in the textile layer. Reads warm in both morning and evening light, photographs beautifully, and forgives almost any natural material near it — jute, stoneware, paper, brass. This is the palette that earns Japandi its "calm but not cold" reputation. Pair with brass, not chrome or black, which throw off the warm temperature.

Use it in: bedrooms, living rooms, entryways — anywhere you want the room to feel slept-in rather than styled. The safest bet for north-facing rooms, where its warmth offsets the cool blue light.

Match against the hex, not the word: off-the-shelf "warm whites" run 4–6% cooler than #F4EEE2.

02 Charcoal & cream

THE ARCHITECTURAL MOVE

BASE	NEUTRAL	WOOD	ANCHOR	ACCENT
Cream #F4EEE2	Stone #C9C0B0	Walnut #A98E6B	Charcoal #3A3936	Sage #9DA897

The high-contrast move. A single deep charcoal element — a wall, a lampshade, a stoneware vessel, a framed sumi-e print — against an otherwise cream and stone room, with walnut doing the warming. Reads architectural; the closest Japandi gets to "moody" without sliding into industrial loft. The discipline is one charcoal element per room — two and it reads heavy rather than considered.

Use it in: home offices and dining rooms, ideally with good natural light. In a low-light or north-facing room, swap the charcoal for a softer warm-black (#1F1E1B), which holds more warmth.

Avoid in bedrooms — the charcoal absorbs more light than it gives back and reads gloomy.

03 Stone & sage

THE BOTANICAL

BASE	NEUTRAL	WOOD	ANCHOR	ACCENT
Cream #F4EEE2	Stone #C9C0B0	Walnut #8A7A5C	Deep walnut #44403A	Sage #9DA897

The most Japanese of the five, pulling from *shibui* — subtle, profound, deliberately understated. Stone-grey linen with one piece of soft sage (bedding, a single throw, a folded blanket at the foot of the bed) against cream walls and walnut wood. Pairs best with darker woods — the cool undertones in sage need warmth from the wood to balance. Aged brass or matte black hardware, never bright brass.

Use it in: bedrooms and bathrooms — the calm, restful rooms. The second-best bedroom palette after oat & oak.

The hardest tone to get right: real Japandi sage (#9DA897) is the underside of an olive leaf, not the cool blue-green eucalyptus emoji. Match against an actual sage cutting.

04 Terracotta accent

THE ONE WARM NOTE

BASE	NEUTRAL	WOOD	ANCHOR	ACCENT
Warm cream #F7F4EE	Oat #E8DCC4	Light oak #C9A77C	Soft black #3A3936	Terracotta #C97B5C

If you want one warmer colour, it's terracotta — never coral, never rust, specifically the muted brick-red of unfired clay (#C97B5C). It's the single accent Calm & Oak uses across the whole brand, including the ampersand. Pair with warm cream walls, light oak, and one soft-black grounding element — a lamp base, a picture frame, a ring dish.

Use it in: kitchens, dining rooms, entryways. Used sparingly — a single vessel, the spine of one book, the glow of a paper lantern. Two terracotta items in one room is one too many; the colour earns its place by scarcity.

If your "terracotta" looks orange in afternoon light, it's too warm — the Japandi version keeps grey undertones. Never on the walls.

05 Warm grey monochrome

THE DISCIPLINED

BASE	NEUTRAL	WOOD	ANCHOR	ACCENT
Pale grey #D8D2C6	Warm grey #9A9388	Oak / ash #A98E6B	Charcoal #4A4844	Muted sage #7E8B7A

The most disciplined palette: every colour is a different value of warm grey, layered from pale to charcoal. Sounds bleak on paper; reads like a quiet luxury hotel suite in practice. The whole room sits on one colour axis, which makes texture the entire visual story — layer wool, linen, and stoneware at three weights and it comes alive without a second colour. The wood is the only non-grey element and carries all the warmth.

Use it in: living rooms and home offices with several textile layers (sofa plus throw plus rug; bedding plus curtains).

Avoid in hard-surface rooms like kitchens, where monochrome reads sterile. Break it with a single jute basket, paper lantern, or wool runner.

A QUICK REFERENCE

Which palette, which *room*.

Pick one palette per room and live with it for a season before swapping. Japandi is calm because it's consistent — not because the colours are perfect. The "avoid" column saves more rooms than the "best" one.

Room	Best palette	Second-best	Avoid
Bedroom	1 · Oat & oak	3 · Stone & sage	2 · Charcoal (heavy)
Living room	1 · Oat & oak	5 · Warm grey mono	4 · Terracotta walls
Dining room	4 · Terracotta accent	2 · Charcoal & cream	3 · Stone & sage (cool)
Kitchen	4 · Terracotta accent	1 · Oat & oak	5 · Monochrome (sterile)
Bathroom	3 · Stone & sage	1 · Oat & oak	2 · Charcoal (dark in steam)
Home office	2 · Charcoal & cream	5 · Warm grey mono	4 · Terracotta (distracting)
Entryway	1 · Oat & oak	4 · Terracotta accent	5 · Monochrome (cold welcome)

Two filters narrow it fast: the wood you already have (light oak → 1 or 4; walnut or ash → 2, 3, or 5), and the light (north-facing wants the warmer 1 or 4; strong south light can carry the cooler 2, 3, or 5).

BEFORE YOU COMMIT

Five palette *mistakes.*

1 · Mixing two palettes in one room. Oat & oak on the bedding, terracotta on the rug, charcoal on the art — three palettes wrestling in one space. The room reads busy even though every piece is muted. Pick one and let the wood be the only crossover.

2 · Five different cream tones. Cream walls, oat duvet, ivory throw, soft-white pillowcases, vanilla curtains — all subtly different, all fighting for the same job. Three committed tones beats five indecisive ones. Match swatches against the hex, not your memory of "cream."

3 · Pinterest sage instead of real sage. Most "sage" skews cool blue-green and reads hospital. Real Japandi sage is warmer (#9DA897) — match against an actual sage cutting before committing.

4 · Two of any accent. Two terracotta vessels, two charcoal lamps, two sage cushions. The single-accent rule is what makes every palette work; the second instance dilutes the first into a pattern rather than a focal point.

5 · Painting the walls the accent colour. Terracotta, sage, or charcoal walls put the accent on the largest surface in the room and overwhelm the palette. Walls stay warm cream or warm white; the accent lives in the textiles, the ceramics, and one piece of art.

Calm & Oak

*"A Japandi palette isn't picked. It's narrowed — to five tones
that already agree."*

KEEP GOING

The free palette generator · calmandoak.com/palette

The 5 palettes, in depth · calmandoak.com/journal/japandi-color-palette

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